have portable idols installed in an alcove or puja-room. This practice is sanctified in the *Srimad Bhagavatham* or *Bhagavata Purana* (Part 11, Chapter 27, Sloka 12), which specifies that eight types of material engender permissible forms of idol worship: stone, wood, metal, clay, sand, crystal, a drawing or even just a mental image. Some of the prominent temples were located on the banks of sacred rivers—notably the Ganga, Yamuna, Narmada, Godavari, Krishna, and Kaveri—whose flowing waters were said to have cleansing properties that could purify those who immersed themselves in them.

The Darshanas are the texts of the six principal schools of Hindu philosophy, drawing from many, and are unabashedly intellectual and abstrusely academic in nature. The six (the Shad Darshanas) include three lesser-known schools of Hindu philosophy: the Nyaya School, which emphasises logic and debate; the Vaisheshika School, which sees the universe as made up of countless atoms, each with its own distinctive quality; and the Mimamsa School, which emphasises the role of sacrifice and ritual in seeking salvation (some scholars describe the Vedic religion as Mimamsa Hinduism to distinguish it from the Puranic Hinduism of later years). A fourth, the Yoga School, is better known around the world for its physical practices, but in fact principally focuses on the control of the mind, the breath and the body as the means to attaining the divine samadhi (a state of trance-like meditative consciousness). The central debate in Hindu philosophy is, however, between the two other schools, the oldest, the Sankhya School (so old that it is mentioned in the *Mahabharata*), based on reasoning, which argues the case for dualism or Dvaita (the idea that there is a clear distinction between spirit and matter, between the divine and the worldly) and the newest (founded just over a millennium ago), the Vedanta School, which rejects dualism (Advaita) and sees spirit and matter as essentially one. Vedanta, or ‘the end of the Vedas’, has, thanks to the initial efforts of Adi Shankara and the nineteenth-century preaching of Swami Vivekananda, become the principal school of Hindu philosophy today, as well as the most influential internationally, and is discussed more fully in the next chapter.

Hindus trust the Vedas, but most do not see them as immune to analysis or criticism; it has been axiomatic in Hinduism that what was